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India's strategy must focus on seeding an ecosystem that makes AI accessible and affordable by driving down inference costs

INDIA NEEDS A SOVEREIGN AI ECOSYSTEM

The case for a sovereign AI ecosystem is not about isolation. It is about control, resilience, and relevance on the global stage

► **WE SEE GENERATIVE** artificial intelligence (AI) as a critical inflection point, one that will reshape economies and societies at every level and mark the most consequential wave of technological change in decades. This early-stage technology has the potential to permeate all facets of life, from individual choices to national governance. India, given its economic momentum, demographic strength, and geopolitical standing, cannot afford to stand on the sidelines. It must claim its seat at the table, shaping not only the technology itself but also the global narrative that will define its use, impact, and governance in the years to come.

The development of a Sovereign AI ecosystem in India has emerged as a strategic necessity, not to decouple from the rest of the world, but to secure strategic autonomy by building foundational AI capabilities that address the country's unique needs. Foundational AI models are quickly becoming the infrastructure layer for everything from education and governance

to finance and science. For a country of India's scale, linguistic diversity, and strategic significance, it's imperative that we build these core systems ourselves, not just adopt them. A key reason for India's readiness lies in its proven track record of creating digital public goods like Aadhaar and UPI, which have achieved unmatched scale, trust, and reach across a billion people. This success provides a proven blueprint for how India can scale up AI systems nationwide. By applying the same principles of trust, scale, and accessibility, India can develop AI that serves real needs and strengthens its AI leadership. Moreover, India's rapidly expanding community of developers, researchers, and engineers, combined with focused investment in technology and market readiness, equips it with a formidable talent base to innovate both locally and globally. In this context, the promise of a Sovereign AI ecosystem is both timely and essential, catalysing India to define its own AI journey and contribute meaningfully to the global technology narrative.

Strategic autonomy demands a focus on developing local talent